‘restaurants, cabarets and beaches … or become acquainted with any unknown person.’[67] Cuban disembarkation ports and Soviet military installations were closed off to Cubans. The ballistic missiles were moved in convoys under cover of darkness.

Although US intelligence (with help from their allies) monitored the build-up and identified some of the weapons, they failed to detect the MRBMs for over a month after their arrival. The missiles were stored below decks and the Soviet military went to elaborate lengths to ensure information about their nuclear forces was not communicated in ways that could be intercepted. According to the history of the US National Security Agency, ‘Soviet communications security was almost perfect.’[68]

There were, however, a great many visual sightings from refugees as well as CIA agents. Very few of these were reliable. Many missiles were only partially glimpsed, often at night, when it was difficult to distinguish between thirty-five feet long Surface-to-Air (SAMs) and sixty-seven feet long MRBMs. After the crisis, DCI McCone reported to President Kennedy that of the 3,500 agent and refugee reports, ‘only eight in retrospect were considered as reasonably valid indicators of the deployment of offensive missiles to Cuba.’[69] Nevertheless, these eight included one from a CIA agent (whose messages used old-fashioned secret handwriting). It was this report that precipitated the U-2 overflight on 14 October that brought back photographs of MRBM sites in the San Cristóbal area of western Cuba.[70]

Throughout the crisis US intelligence was unable to verify whether Soviet nuclear warheads had arrived in Cuba, and there was some discussion in ExComm of whether they had even been sent. Washington nevertheless proceeded on the prudent assumption that they were there. In fact, the first cargo of nuclear warheads arrived in Mariel on board the freighter *Indigirka* on 4 October. This comprised thirty-six one-megaton warheads for the R-12s and fifty-four tactical nuclear warheads.

The plan was to deploy sixty MRBMs and IRBMs comprising three R-12 missile regiments (each equipped with eight launchers and twelve missiles) from the Ukraine and European Russia, together with two R-14 regiments (each equipped with eight launchers and twelve missiles).[71] Some 550 R-12s were currently targeted against NATO Europe. The weapon was an